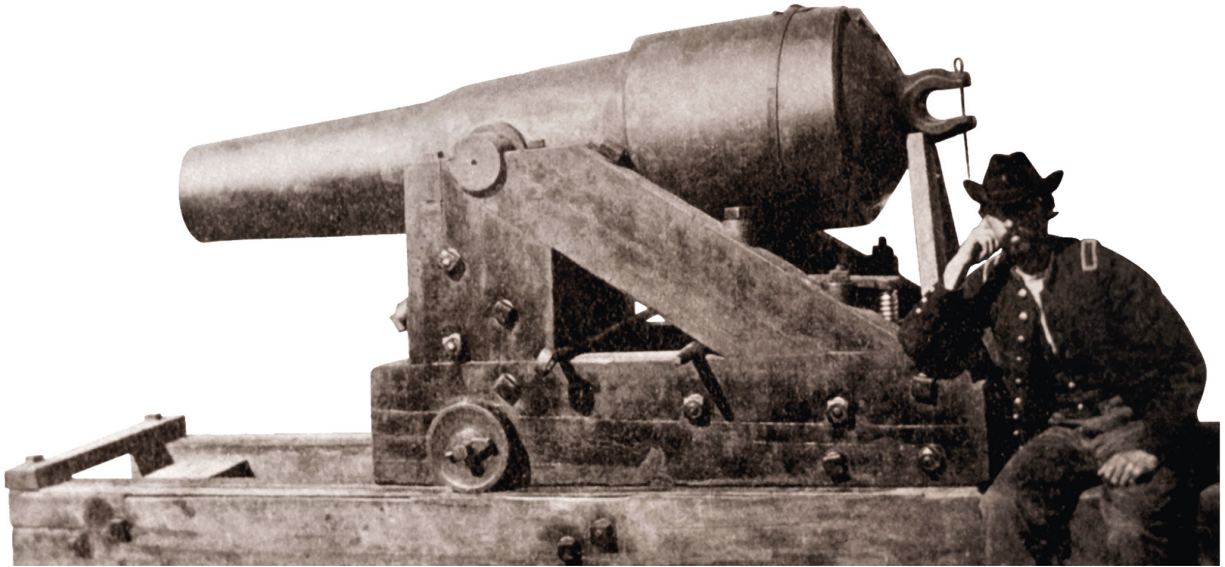


several dozen of their enemy (some of whom were later sold into slavery), before being driven off.



"Whistling Dick"

This 18-pounder (8kg) gun in the Vicksburg defenses gained its nickname from the unusual noise its shells made. The barrel could be aimed to fire downward at targets on the river from its position on the Vicksburg bluffs.

Tightening the noose

Within Vicksburg, as the realization set in that Johnston and Taylor were not coming to their relief, the city's defenders lost the high morale they had in May, along with their physical strength. Grant wired Washington: "The fall of Vicksburg and the capture of most of the garrison can only be a question of time." Every day Pemberton's soldiers grew weaker; by the end of June, almost half were on sick lists.

Consulting with his generals, the Confederate commander confirmed his suspicions that a breakout attack would certainly fail. He was determined to hold out, however, despite the long odds, confident that some event outside his entrenchments would either draw Grant away or force him to lift the siege. On June 28, Pemberton received a letter signed by a group of enlisted men declaring that, "If you can't feed us, you had better surrender us, horrible as the idea is ..." He knew the game was up. The letter